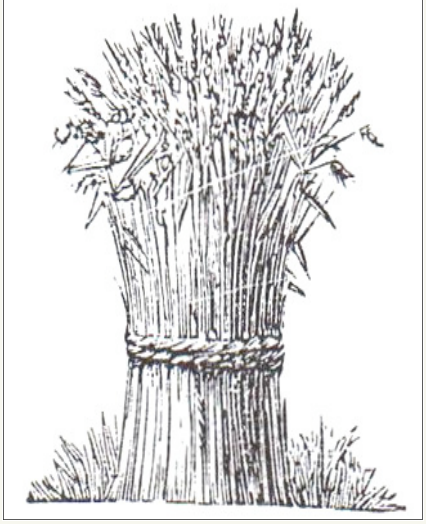
Volume 2 Issue 2

Fall 2008

# Hollerbeier Haven

Newsletter for the Herbal and Healing Arts



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*Happy Harvest!* At Three Sisters Center we have been busy with ongoing work, and preparing for big changes. The past few months have certainly been adventurous! We spent much of June preparing for our time at the Kutztown Folk Festival, and plenty of July recovering from it! Our information was well received at the festival, with many new people finding interest in Braucherei, and many familiar ones stopping by to say hello. It was a hot and sticky week, but well worth the effort. During our time at the festival we made many more connections with people who may have more information to share with us about the Braucherei tradition, which we hope to explore soon.

Jesse and Matthew have kept themselves busy for the past few months teaching and seeing clients, and preparing for the birth of their baby due to arrive in November. The arrival of the baby will undoubtedly change Jesse's teaching schedule, so she is trying to prepare as much as possible ahead of time to account for the changing demands on her time and energy. In the Braucherei Weg course, Jesse has had two students who have been taking the course for college credit through the Prescott College ADP program. The two are our own Lauren Sicher and Annie Hasz, a long time friend of the Three Sisters' Center.

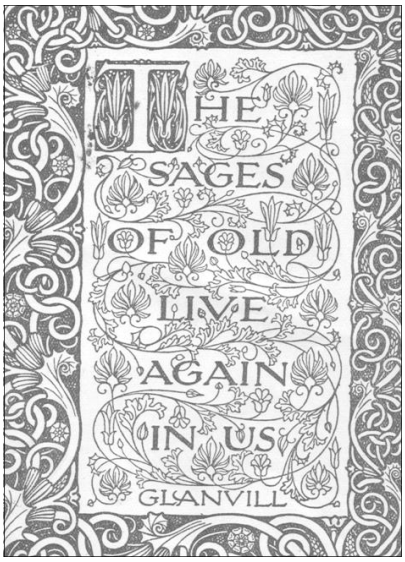
Susan's classes on the farm are winding down to a close this fall but her teaching ventures off the farm recently have raised the awareness of many others interested in herbalism. A presentation on PA German Herbs at the International Herb Association Conference in July was well received and earned Susan an invitation to speak at an herb conference sponsored by the University of Illinois in January. Susan also recently spoke to a homeschooling group of ninety children on the medicinal and folkloric uses of herbs. She continues to gather and compile research on herbal uses of the early PA Germans.

Lauren has been continuously transcribing interviews. She has finished the bulk of Dennis Boyer's work and is now moving on to the newer interviews conducted by Jesse, Matthew, and Susan. We try to keep a constant flow of them going her way, and her fingers keep flying on the keyboard! We were lost before her fast-typing fingers came along. Lauren has also been preparing a presentation and paper for the Braucherei Weg that will examine in-depth the animal symbolism of the Oley-Pikeville calendar and compare it with the symbolism of traditional Greek Astrology.

Patrick has had a very eventful several months. His lecture at the PA German Cultural Heritage Center's Barn Conference was met with nothing but enthusiasm from scholars and laymen alike. His in-depth study and unique understanding of the sacred geometry and symbolism found in the traditional barn art of the PA Germans has elevated him to a level on par with scholars of barn architecture and design who have spent decades in their fields. He is now in the process of documenting all of the hex signs of Berks county: photographing, mapping, and decoding their meanings. We are truly lucky to have him as our apprentice this year.

There is always a lot going on in our continuous expanding projects at the Three Sisters' Center and we are always excited to share it with you!

*Blessings, Jesse and Susan*




The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts (Transcription)

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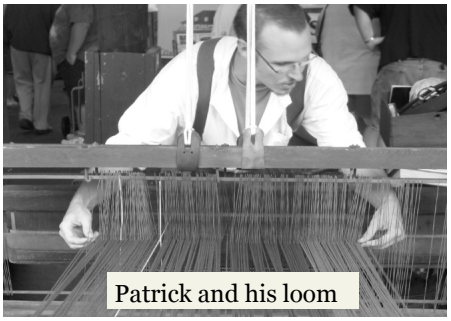
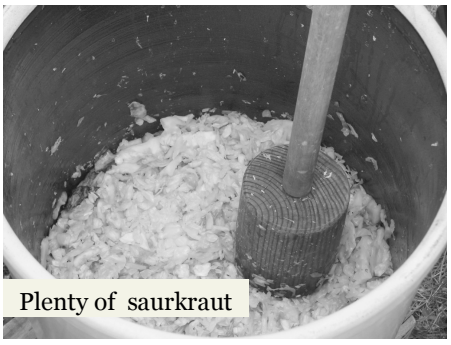
# KUTZTOWN Pennsylvania German FESTIVAL

Matthew, Rob Lusch and Jesse

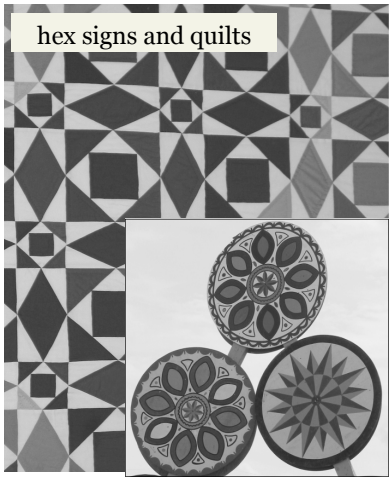

Patrick and his loom

Susan


Plenty of saurkraut

good food

Lauren


hex signs and quilts

# Reviving Diversity by Jesse Tobin

In the twentieth century the Braucherei tradition and Germanic culture as a whole has suffered many blows. Not the least of these were the events leading up to, and the realities of the two world wars. It was during and after those times that Germans in America experienced marked shame and prejudice simply for their ethnic identity. This was a time when the mother tongue was cut off, intentionally kept from the minds and hearts of children; when names were changed (Schmidt became Smith overnight); and time honored traditions were left behind, firmly wrapped in the stigma of their "German-ness".

We are in a different time and a different place in our cultural history today. In most western cultures there is a level of tolerance for diversity that exists now that is nearly unprecedented in the global community. There is a relative peace that exists in which people of all creeds, colors, and even sexual orientation can coexist, live and let live. In some ways it is as though the holy experiment of Pennsylvania has finally come to fruition.

Yet this peace and tolerance is balanced on the very thin edge of a knife. The slip of a foot might throw the whole thing out of balance and send us into a terrible fall. Outside of urban centers, many minority groups still have to duck and cover to keep themselves out of harm's way. Hate groups, whether organized (as in the case of the KKK or Arian Nation) or loosely held together, are sadly still a strong voice in America and abroad. Everyday I hear stories of random acts of violence. Sometimes it is the Islamic community that is targeted in these times of war, sometime Latin or African Americans. Last week I heard a story from my sister of a gruesome attack in Ashville, NC on a youth who was beaten to the point of disfigurement, and nearly to the point of death simply because he was walking to a known gay bar. This attack occurred in front of a church.

It seems that there will always be those who are so fearful of diversity, of the unknown other, that they are more willing to cause tremendous pain in the name of their own superiority than they are to listen and learn. It also seems that there is no end to the violence that is committed in the name of God and of Jesus Christ. What a horrid and warped misinterpretation it is of the works and teachings of Jesus such violence is!

In light of this ongoing presence of hate, I would like to examine our own history in the hope of preventing the repetition of it. The German holocaust did not just pop into existence out of nowhere, there were many contributing factors: culture, economy, and latent racism.

The latent racism against the Jews of Europe was something that had been in existence since the time of the first crusade. Since that time European Jews experienced alternating waves of tolerance and persecution, with persecution usually winning out. Other groups persecuted during the time of the Third Reich included Gypsies, Homosexuals, and dissenters. These groups faced many of the same concerns and waves of persecution as the Jews and were often wiped out in mass genocides along side them.

In order to understand the events of World War II we have to travel further back in time to the 19th century. Of particular relevance are the works of the Grimm Brothers and their contemporaries. Jacob and Wilhelm Grimm made it their lives' work to recover and revive the folk knowledge of the German people. Up until this point in history there had never been a concerted effort to create a coherent Germanic identity: there had never been a state that unified German-speaking Europeans; there had never been a truly unified standard German language; there had certainly never been a unified mythological backdrop through which the German identity was solidified. The Grimm brothers sought to create a united people in the face of the French occupation of Germany, and later against the fragmented German ethnic identity created through the narrow and oppressive German Princes.

Their work was an answer to the French occupation, and also an answer to another issue of the time (one that was felt on both sides of the Atlantic): the pressures of urbanization and industrialization. Such pressures were beginning to tear at the fabric of traditional society: dismantling traditional trades and rendering them obsolete; removing people from their agrarian cultures and languages and placing them in the often toxic environment and poverty of the urban experience; dismantling the extended family communities that held the culture together as nuclear families left the village in search of work. This was a time of great political upheaval in German lands, with democratic movements coming in waves of peasant revolt across the countryside.

Although the Grimms were certainly not the first to begin the study of Germanic folklore, they have certainly become the most famous. The Grimms and others worked tirelessly to create the works that have come down to us. The most well known of their works is decidedly the vast volume of children's stories, *The Complete Fairy Tales of the Brothers Grimm*. Beyond this beloved work, however, there is much more to be had. Together, the Grimms created several books of mythology and legends. Jacob, in particular, created volumes of work. His most notable was his *Teutonic Mythology*, a four-volume set of in-depth research and portrayals of the mythological themes and worldviews of the Germanic people. Jacob also worked to create coherent works of German Grammar, Ancient German Law, and the first standard German dictionary (though he died before he reached even the middle).

Continued on page 4...

Diversity continued from page 3...

Others of this era were delving into, and romanticizing the many sagas and mythologies of the Germanic and Nordic peoples. The most notable of these romanticized sagas is Wagner's operatic rendition of *The Niebelungenlied.* The study of rune lore and all things ancient and occult returned to the forefront, with many differing interpretations and methods of understanding. There was a sense of recovery of great wisdom, of cultural wealth, and of a steady movement forward.

Unfortunately all of this groundbreaking research and careful study was warped in the early twentieth century to serve the hands of the powerful. It was turned from a tool of preservation and revival, from a beacon to which all could turn and receive their cultural inheritance, from work of the people, to a weapon of propaganda and racism.

During the time of the Third Reich many elements of research done in the name of German identity were usurped and warped into Hitler's propaganda of a master race. With the ancient and sacred symbol of Thor's hammer adorning their uniforms and flags, the Nazi machine smashed through the lives of millions of Jews, Gypsies, and dissenters. It robbed the German people of their cultural wealth by usurping and twisting it to the ends of the propaganda machine. By the end of the war the pride and identity felt by those who laid the groundwork of cultural revival had been turned on its head to a collective sense of shame and cultural self-loathing.

It is amazing how easily this can happen, how one generation's pride can become the next generation's horror and shame. To those who lived through the war, the revival work we are carrying on now might look like a scary repetition of history. I am determined that it not be, for there are greater things to be done in our time.

There is a fine line to walk in any act of cultural revival. Unfortunately, some do choose to look deeply into their ancestral culture from a sense of superiority and carry their pride inextricably bound to their racism. They call this pride. I cannot call it anything but what it is: fear, ignorance, and weakness.

At Three Sisters Center, we approach the subject of cultural revival from a very different angle: one of increasing ethnic diversity. One of the most important things that environmentalists, biologists, and ecologists have found is that the healthiest ecosystems, and the most overall productive ecosystems for the planet, are the ones with the most biodiversity. I would argue that the same is true for the human mindscape: that ethnic, cultural, and linguistic diversity makes us stronger as a global community.

Historically each group of traditional people had carved a niche out of their local environment. The Saami have learned best, through millennia of life experience, how to live in the far north of Europe. The same is true of the desert people of Saudi Arabia, the mountain people of Nepal, and the oceanic people of Polynesia. People are healthiest, and so is the planet, when we adapt and adjust our traditional ways to suit the environment that surrounds us.

The influence of place comes out to shine in our folk cultural traditions. A wonderful example of this is the Muun Raad (moon wheel) of the Oley Freindschaft. In this example we see the old influences of Europe (the Astrological Wheel of the year) adapt to the new environment in which it now exists (the foothills of the Pennsylvanian Appalachian Mountains). Each of the traditional moons, though still associated with the old sign (Taurus, Pisces, Leo, etc), is now also named for and associated with a new world animal (Wood duck, Crow, Frog, etc.). This sort of adaptation is the beautiful and inevitable reality of a living, thriving, evolving culture.

In the time since the Industrial Revolution, however, much of this sort of traditional knowledge has been intentionally dismantled, and systematically destroyed. Often this was done "for the people's own good", to bring various groups of traditional people into the modern era. This happened in areas of medicine, agriculture, architecture, language, commerce, and many, many more. Each culture has their own story of cultural destruction, each tragedy has its own specifics, but the same general theme: we have moved, as a global community, toward a place of homogenization and standardization.

In mindset of most people over the past two hundred years, this idea of homogenization was a good thing, a goal to be doggedly sought after. Milk is now homogenized, Languages have been standardized, Agriculture in general has turned into monocrop propagation, Medicine has become an industry, and Industry is constantly streamlined for the most effective, most commercially productive possible organization. And so it is only now, now that all of this is complete that we can see with clear eyes the error of our ways: It is only when we have destroyed so much in the name of standardization that we can see that most of us cannot digest homogenized milk, that our cultures are poorer for the loss of our languages, that the fertile soils of the earth cannot withstand this constant pillage of plough and pesticides, that the diseases that haunted us for all our history are nothing to the ones that have evolved at the hands of medical science, and that for all the exactness of Industry, the life support system of the planet could collapse at any moment.

One of the main problems facing the sustainability revolution is this homogenization. In some ways it has certainly served us, but in others it has created unfathomable obstacles. Either way, it has become synonymous with our modern societies. So how do we solve these problems?

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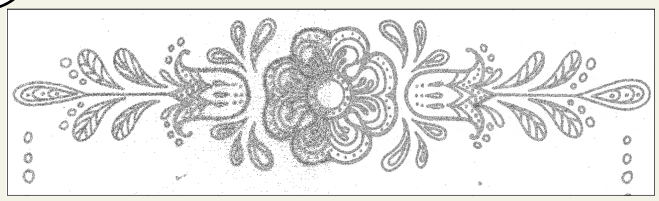


Diversity continued from page 4...

First, it is very important to say that we cannot employ the tools of homogenization to solve its problematic outcomes: so there is no one solution that will work to heal the whole world. The time for the "one size fits all" approach is over, and it is time to move into the realm of creativity, innovation, and the cumulative effect of the small everyday actions of 6 billion and counting. I believe that the key to finding a sustainable and peaceful future is for each of us to carry our own unique piece of culture and tradition forward to meet the challenges of the lives before us.

Just as each animal and plant in the rainforest has its own special niche, each of our local cultures carries information, worldviews, and traditional practices and techniques that are entirely unique. We are most likely to find the best options for our communities and our world by looking to these traditional ways with new and creative eyes. The way to the future is not backward. We cannot simply return to traditional life 500 years ago. That world is gone. We can learn from, however, and incorporate aspects of traditional life, revive these ways into our current fragmented cultures. Just as the blighted potatoes of Ireland needed a dose of resistant and more diverse genes from the older varieties of Peru, we need to take a dose of ancient wisdom with clarity and openness to survive and flourish.

That being said, it falls to each of us to do this work as best we can for our own local cultures. I cannot work to revive traditional Kenyan culture, it is not my culture, my identity, or my community, and most importantly I do not live in Kenya. Our European German relatives cannot work to revive our culture for the same reasons... they are not here; it is not theirs to do our work for us. We each have a piece to carry, and it is for this diverse landscape of culture, and for our own local enrichment, that Three Sisters' does the work it does.

It is important to remember, however, that Deitsch local culture has no value in isolation. It is not special when it is not seen as something unique from its Latino, English, Irish, Polish, and Italian neighbors. We all have our own ways, our own foods, and our own outlooks, but we add ever greater value to each other when we share with, and live in tolerance and understanding of one another.

Bigotry serves no purpose in a movement toward our common future, and only creates more pain. In the coming years we will have no room in this world for those who live only for the judgment and harm of others. It is time after all to allow the time of the blossoming lily, for the divine experiment of Penn's woods to fully encompass our lives and our purpose, to create our future with intention and love, and embracing the vast richness of our diversity.

## *Some Interesting Topical Remedies Extensively Used for Coughs and Sore Throats by the PA Germans...*

*Fried onions, still very warm, should be spread on the soles of the feet and bound with wool cloth

*Animal fat (preferably goose grease) was heated and smeared over the chest and back and wrapped in a red woolen cloth

*A footbath in warm water while drinking hot elderflower and peppermint tea sweetened with honey. (This also used for fever)

*The left stocking was turned wrong side out and wrapped around the neck to cure a sore throat. Keep in mind that the sock was not to be a clean one, but one that was well worn and smelly!

From 'Beliefs and Superstitions of the Pennsylvania Germans' (1915)
by Edwin Miller Fogel, Ph.D.

En heemgschpunnener wollicher Faade um der Hals ghenkt kyurrt Schtickfluss.

Translation to be found somewhere within the pages of this newsletter!!

# ~The Tree Of Life ~ Der Lewwebaam

by Lauren Sicher

Braucherei is a tradition that holds within it many varied techniques. Among these are practices of prayer healing (Bedeheelen); written, visual, or physical prayers (hex signs, Himmelsbrief, and ceremony) and a range of shamanic techniques. In these techniques one goes into a dream-like state through various practiced meditation methods. Some Brauchers use bells, drums, rattles, music, chanting, or simply silence to help them attain this state. When in this state it is like a dream but it can be controlled and directed more easily. Brauchers use this medium for many things such as speaking with ancestors, Blantzeschwetze (speaking with plants), Diereschwetze (speaking with animals), Seeleheelen (soul healing), or speaking with other spirits, angels, or departed teachers.

In this other "world" there is a well trodden landscape which includes: an upper world, middle world, and lower world. The upper world is considered to hold what we call teachers, who are our guides in life and in the spirit world. These teachers can range from an angel, saint, highly evolved human spirit, to figures such as Jesus Christ himself. They are always there for us whether we know it or not. The lower world holds our guides in life and in the spirit world. These guides can be any animal that is real, mythical, or extinct, as well as plant spirits, ancestral spirits, and all those teachers who have past. Each of these beings has something to teach us about ourselves or the matters at hand. They present themselves as we need them.

The middle world is considered the world that we live in. Here our teachers, animal spirits, guides, and other spirits interact with us if we are aware. An animal or plant may show up often when you take a walk, drive, are gardening, or just looking out the window. A teacher may show up too, especially if it's an ancestor, teacher, or friend that was known in life. These reminders of people can come in many ways: a lingering scent, a gesture, an article of clothing, or a tool could serve as a reminder as a loved ones teachings or influence.

The tree of life, sometimes called the world tree, is the connection of these three worlds and of life in general. This concept is repeated and across the globe in different cultures and mythologies: Norse, Hungarian, Celtic, Siberian, Hindu, and Native American to name a few. It is visualized as a massive tree with branches and roots that extend up into heaven and the upper world, also into the underworld and lower world.

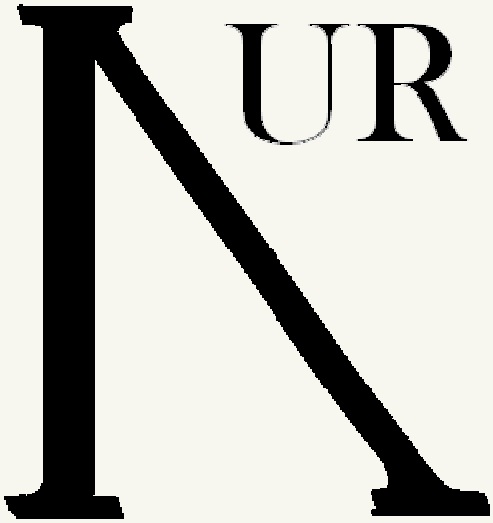
We have this tree in Braucherei and have received information from several Brauchers about it. A woman from Perry County said that she went to this tree every time she journeyed into other worlds. She learned all of this through journeying and not by studying. This woman along with most Brauchers emphasized that each person needed to use what worked for them. She referred to this journeying as Saether (also spelled Seidhr– ed.)which she said is a teutonic shamanic practice. She called the tree of life the Lewebaam and found that the tree had nine regions which she referred to as die Gegend (regions). Each of the regions on the tree held a different purpose for her.

The very top of the tree was Hoehgegend (high realm) and that was the place of divinity. The next section was the upper branches of the tree named the Himmelgegend (heavenly realm) and that held spiritually advanced ancestors. The Hatzholz (heart wood) was the trunk of the tree. She said that this represented the visible world which correlates with the idea that middle world (the world we live in) is the trunk. The upper roots were known to her as the Unnergegend (lower realm). Here were the earth-based spirits and evolving ancestral spirits (spirits waiting to be reborn). Dunkelgegend was the dark realm and a place of destruction and transformation. There were four separations for the leaves of the world tree. Die Nardbledder are north leaves which she deemed the place of ice. Die Sudbledder or the south leaves are known by her as the place of fire. Die Oschtobledder, the east leaves, are the place of magic, and die Weschtbledder (west leaves) are the place of spiritual journey. In this journeying she said one finds three branches called the Engelfetsch and these are angelic beings. The third helper is from the trunk and leaves and they are Zwarichfetsch or dwarves.

Continued on page 12...

# Ur - The Mighty Aurochs by Patrick Donmoyer

*'The wild ox is fierce,*
*With horns above,*
*A bold Fighter who steps the moor,*
*A mighty creature.'*
-Anglo-Saxon Rune Poem
(Taken from Horik Svensson's The Runes)




Ur, the second rune in the Germanic Futhark sequence, is a letter named for what was once the most powerful creature in Europe, the Aurochs. This enormous species of cow, extinct as of the late Renaissance, is believed by some to have migrated originally from India, making the aurochs widespread through much of Europe and Asia. The Aurochs can be seen depicted in painted form on the walls of the famous Paleolithic archeological sites of the Lascaux and Livernon caves in France. The Aurochs seems to have inhabited the collective imagination of the Indo-Europeans as representative of the powerful masculine force of nature. Seen in contrast to the first Germanic rune Feoh, Ur is the proverbial Yin to Feoh's Yang. While Feoh represents nature's abundance, fertility and positive affirmation to human life, The Aurochs represents nature's challenge and struggle. The Aurochs was hunted for food, and required bands of hunters to work together in groups to bring down the massive creature. Tales of the aurochs hunts were epics of violence and the human ability to persevere in the presence of impossible odds. In many cultures, including both the Ancient Germans and the Greeks, a young man's rite of passage included a confrontation with an Aurochs as proof of the transition to manhood. The Aurochs is believed to have been associated with magic, analogous to the vitality of Mars, representing masculinity, but also transmissive power, as it bestows the rite of manhood. But do not be fooled into believing that the Aurochs applies only to masculinity. The bull has been often associated with the goddesses of antiquity. Bulls as well as dragons guard the Babylonian Gates of Ishtar.

In divination, Ur represents the challenges life presents to us, and the possibility to overcome adversity through transformation. The presence of Ur in a rune casting indicates the presence of a necessary challenge, and the ability to overcome it through conviction and effort. As Ur is one of the runes that has no horizontal axis of symmetry, it has two properties: one when upright, a second in reversed form. Reversed, Ur indicates that a querent may not be prepared for the challenge being presented. This can indicate a lack of energy, fear or avoidance. Ur reversed could also portend the removal of a potential challenge, indicating that the querent could be spared the opportunity to engage in a struggle. It is important to remember that although a rune's meaning can be reversed, this does not necessarily have to represent a simple duality of good and bad, positive and negative, but rather a different way of looking at the nature of the symbol, and how the querent can choose to respond. The concept of struggle does not easily fit into a dual framework, as life is filled with and defined by our relationship to struggle. Ur can imply transformation in either case.

This article is the third in a series aimed at explaining the symbolism behind the Germanic runes and their implications in divination. These explanations are intended to introduce each of the concepts individually, but it is important to remember that the context of the divination, as well as each rune's proximity to another in a casting can radically change the implications of each symbol. Later articles will further discuss the interactions between the different runes, and how each leaf fallen from the tree of Yggdrasil shares a common source.

# Der Seel, Ihres Lied

By Jesse Tobin

Oh, ich sing fer eich, mei Freinde lieb,
Zu alle Mensche, Dier, un Blanz.
Un ich sag an eich: “Schteh uff! Schteh uff!
Uns Arrewet iss in Lieb zu dans!”
Un nieman kann uns Dans Verschtopp.
Net Deifel, Sarrige, Bangichkeet.
Es Himmelreich schteht do in Leb.
Grischdus wuhnt in uns jedem Hauch.

Oh, Sophia singt ihr seeles Lied
Darrich menschlich Hatz un Seel.
Sie webt in uns ihr heilige Light
Weesheet erleest uns, ebberall.
Un heer mich gut! Der Weg is datt!
Der Weg liegt in es menschlich Hatz
Die licht scheint vun der Seele raus,
Erleest uns alle, erleest uns nau.

Oh, ich kann net es all erzehl.
Wuhie mir geh, wuvun mir kumm.
Ich wees yuscht eener Waahret:
es Heilige Geischt fliesst darrich all
In jedem Baum, uff jedem Berg,
Un darrich jede Fluss un gwelle,
Es gebt ken Gwalt wie selli Gwalt:
Die Graft es menschlich Hatz zu heel.

# The Song of the Soul

~translation~

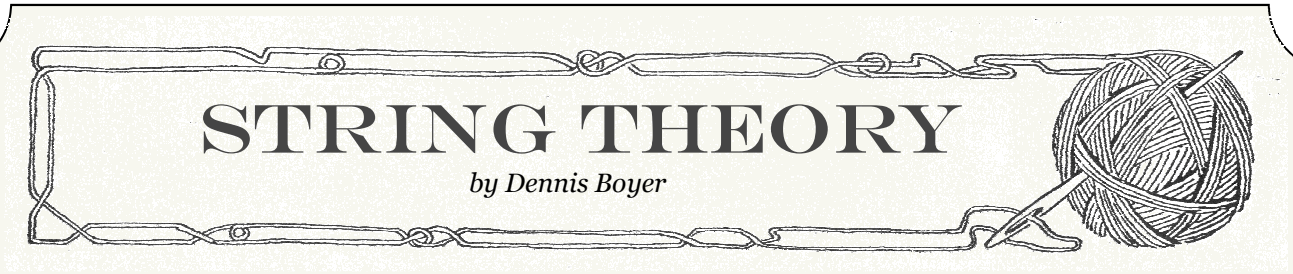
Oh, I sing for you, my dear friends!
To all man, beasts, and plants,
And I say to you, “Stand up! Stand up!
Our work is here in love to dance.”
And no one can forestall our dance.
No fear, no worry, no devils here.
The kingdom of heaven is here in life.
Christ lives in our every breath.

Oh, Sophia sings her soulful song
Through the human heart and soul.
She weaves in us her holy light.
Wisdom saves us one and all!
And listen well! The way is there!
The way lies in the human heart.
The light shines out from heart and soul,
Redeems us all, redeems us now.

Oh, I cannot explain it all.
Where we go to, or come from.
I know just one truth in my heart,
The Holy Ghost flows through it all:
In every tree, on every mountain
And through every stream or spring
There is no power like this power:
The strength to heal the human heart.

# STRING THEORY

*by Dennis Boyer*



"All forms of healing depend on establishing connections to the energy we depend on", claimed the young woman Braucher's apprentice. "I picked up at least that much from Grandmother while she still lived on the old family homestead near Lobachsville".

Like so many younger Pennsylvania Germans the young woman had struggled to find a way to continue traditions and make them meaningful in a contemporary context. She had picked up a fair amount of her grandmother's powwowing art while visiting as a girl.

But the old woman had declined in body and mind before her granddaughter could be brought into formal instruction.

"Grandmother went into a nursing home in Pottstown in the early 1990s. She would still talk about powwow medicine and I was always open to listening. I guess I was always drawn to it. Some have told me that I seem intuitive about it. Still, there were many questions I wish I would have thought to ask her while she was available.

"I bet you've heard that lament before. It seems like we came very close to losing some of that knowledge entirely. We treated it so casually, like it would just be there whenever we wanted to pluck some up at our convenience. After Grandmother was gone I searched for years before I could find anyone who could help me get grounded in powwow medicine."

The young woman's story was indeed a familiar one. Those in search of cures and training in the arts of Braucherei, not to mention many a folklorist and anthropologist, have struggled to access the Braucher's world. But just as familiar is the oft-related account of suddenly happening upon an abundance of powwowing connections that were there all along.

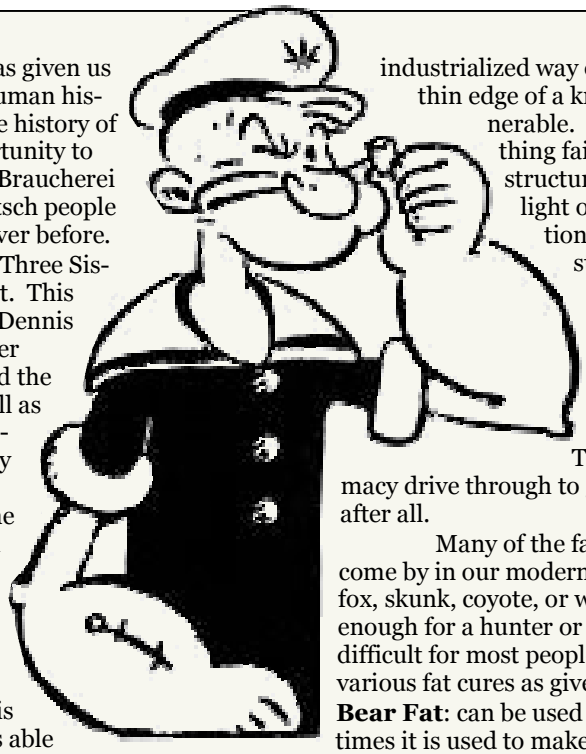
"I finally found an old-timey Braucher here near Bechtelsville. The type that I'd heard about, but that everyone tells you has died out. A tobacco-chewing, bib overalls-wearing, whiskey-drinking retired farmer who still feels more at home in the barn than in the house. It was from him that I first learned the words 'Braucher' and 'Braucherei'. He was reluctant at first to take me under his wing in the old way, he claimed it just wasn't done anymore. But I kept visiting him and telling him what I remembered of Grandmother. And he helped me understand her practices better. In the process he started to see that, whether he intended to or not, he was teaching me. The deal clincher though came in the form of a lemon sponge cake I made him. He was convinced that if I could get that right, powwowing was child's play."

The Braucher's apprentice lived a double life for a number of years, commuting each weekday to the office parks of King of Prussia and visiting with the old Braucher on weekends. She soon realized that in some respects she had a better knowledge base in Braucherei than he did. But she was also humbled in his presence as well, recognizing in him the Spirit of Braucherei that connected him to the energy and light of the healing path.

"My teacher was a simple man, but I think I learned the most important lessons of Braucherei from him. I learned that there were things more important than technique and memorizing the cures. He lived the life of connection to others and Spirit and helped me understand how I could stay connected to both he and Grandmother through all time.

"It started when I asked him about Grandmother's 'powwow strings', something I recalled, but didn't understand. He knew right away what they were and had some experience with them. It turned out that some Brauchers worked with threads, string, yarn, and so forth. There apparently were many ways to work with such things. My teacher said he had worked with baler twine in barns and even heavy rope outdoors.

Continued on page 12...



# Popeye's Fat Cures

Life in an industrialized nation has given us Americans a unique perspective in human history. For perhaps the first time in the history of our species we have had the opportunity to become squeamish. Learning about Braucherei and the old time medicine of the Deitsch people has made this more apparent than ever before.

Part of our ongoing work at Three Sisters Center is the Elder Voices Project. This project aims to continue the work of Dennis Boyer, collecting the herbal and prayer cures, the agricultural know-how, and the spiritual wisdom of our elders (as well as more than a few off-color jokes in Deitsch). The elders we find vary greatly in their perspectives and characters: saints and sinners, the refined and the rednecks, we listen to and learn from them all. As you have seen in the recent issues of Hollerbeier Haven, Lauren has been working to transcribe and share information from the interviews Dennis collected over many years of folkloric research. His work is unique in the fact that he was able to catch and hold onto so much information that very few people valued at the time. If it were not for his timeliness we would have lost much more than I care to think on.

In our ongoing interviews, however, we are always finding new and exciting information as well. Among them are the "fat cures" we learned of from one of the elders living in the Kutztown Area.

"Popeye" is one of our most enthusiastic characters, and very typical of Deitsch men of his era. He can flow from the depths of spiritual thought to his favorite lewd joke in an instant. He grew up in a time and a place that was simply more practical and hard, and his knowledge of folk medicine reflects that. His stubborn, traditional nature has allowed him to take huckleberry leaf tea in the face of a hospital doctor to cure his own kidney stones. He uses herbal and prayer healing along with a variety of other traditional cures to keep him and his family healthy and whole.

Most interesting to me were his "fat cures". Although Popeye knows a range of herbs, prayers, and energy techniques, he talked more about the fat cures than anything else. The fat I am talking about is the rendered fat of several different animals, which, when applied topically, offer relief from a range of ailments for man and beast.

This is where the modern American might tend to get squeamish and back away from tradition in favor of some less "salt of the earth" type of cure. Rendering the fat out of the Christmas goose might be comfortable for most, but the rendered fat of a dog or bear is entirely another for most people. It is easy in our current age to write off these cures as unnecessary, superstitious, or backward. It is important to remember, however, that our society and our super-industrialized way of life are sustained on the very thin edge of a knife. It is so fragile and so vulnerable. Should one relatively small thing fail, the collapse of the whole structure is quite easy to imagine. In light of the enormous loss of traditional medicine, agriculture, construction, and food preservation that has occurred over the course of the 20th century, I put forward that it is not only interesting, but also vital to preserve and revive the knowledge of these traditional cures. There may not always be a pharmacy drive through to go to for our medical needs, after all.

Many of the fats discussed below are hard to come by in our modern society. Things such as bear, fox, skunk, coyote, or wild rabbit fat would be easy enough for a hunter or trapper to come by, but will be difficult for most people to find. Following are the various fat cures as given to us by Popeye:

**Bear Fat**: can be used for a variety of things. Sometimes it is used to make a rich soap. Popeye uses it as a salve for drawing, both for infection and for splinters of any kind. It can also be used topically for bruises, or for skin irritation or rash (particularly in the areas between the legs or around the groin).

**Dog Fat**: Popeye remembers that dog fat was used mostly for swellings in the joints. He remembers his father applying dog fat to the leg of a lame racehorse. He said the horse returned to racing very soon after. He said it would also be used on fingers, knees, or elbows that were swollen, stiff, or painful. He specifically said he would use it for "tight tendons" and carpal tunnel syndrome. When Popeye's father was alive he would get the dog fat from a local veterinarian when dogs were euthanized in his clinic. Now he does not use it as there are strict laws which forbid this practice.

Domestic dogs are protected by the S.P.C.A., and many wild dogs are protected because they are threatened species. I would suggest that it is quite possible that Coyote or Fox fat could be substituted for domestic dog fat. There is no closed season for Coyote hunting; the season is year-round and unlimited. Coyote can be hunted with a fur bearing or other hunting license. Fox hunting season is more restricted, only October 25th to February 21st. Fox can be hunted with a furbearing license.

**Goose Grease**: Popeye uses rendered goose grease for the carrier in a chest "schmier" for bad coughs. He cooks ground ivy and pine tar into the goose grease and rubs the mixture on the chest and back. After applying the mixture the sick person is instructed to put on an old sweatshirt and go to bed. Popeye used this himself for a case of Pneumonia when other things were not helping quickly enough. He recovered quickly after using this salve, surprising his doctors.

*By Chesse and Popeye*

Continued on page 12...

# ELECAMPANE

## *Inula helenium*

*Olandswartzel, elfdock,*

Elecampane is an impressive plant in the garden, growing to a height of six feet. The flowers resemble sunflowers, growing up to 4 inches wide with long thin yellow petals and blooms all summer. The lower leaves can grow to a length of 20 inches and are covered with coarse hairs. The plant is perennial and the roots should be collected for medicinal use in the fall of the second year. Older plants produce roots that are too woody for use. In China the flowers of elecampane are used as well as the root as an expectorant

Traditional medicinal uses: .Exceptionally good lung herb, however it is exceptionally bitter! It is used for deep persistent coughs. Has good antiviral and antibacterial activity

1)Useful for pneumonia, bronchitis, croup, irritating cough. In larger quantities, can also be used for whooping cough, tuberculosis.

2) Because of it's extreme bitterness and activity in the digestive system, it can be used for treating an array of intestinal parasites, amoebic dysentery, giardia, etc. Can be taken propholactically when traveling to prevent food poisoning, salmonella, E. coli, pinworms, etc.

Topical Use: Has good antibacterial activity for topical use

Contraindications: Elecampane should not be used during pregnancy

## Interesting Historical Facts and Folklore

This herb was of such importance to the PA Germans that it was the very first one that was included in the 1762 issue of Sauer's Herbal. Even previous to this time, elecampane was considered to have marvelous curative powers

The root of elecampane was widely recommended for chewing (instead of tobacco) during the yellow fever epidemic of 1793 as a preventative against contagion. If chewing wasn't an option it was to be infused in wine or beer. This was used for all sorts of coughs, bronchitis, etc. In fact, elecampane was the number one remedy for veterinary medicine, as well. The root was fed to coughing horses.

For consumption, elecampane was combined equally with wild cherry bark, dogwood bark and hops and decocted and reduced. It was then made into syrup with either loaf sugar or rock candy.

Because of the extreme bitterness of the root, elecampane was also helpful for stimulating 'weak' digestive organs.

References:

Plant Names and Plant Lore among the PA Germans-Brendle (1927)
Sauer's Herbal Cures -- William Woys Weaver (2001)
A Modern Herbal– Mrs. M. Grieve (1931)

Herbal Therapeutics –David Winston, AHG (2003)
Herbalpedia- The Herb Growing & Marketing Network Herbworld.com

*String Theory continued from page 9…*

"The basic idea was to make design outlines with the string or whatever. You can almost see this as temporary healing art. You might even think of it as a Dutch mandala. The most common designs were variations on hex signs, but there really wasn't any limit to what the Braucher could come up with that represented the necessary energetic field.

"Apparently the old way was to outline the design with pegs on a board and wind string around them to create the design. The end of the string was usually 'grounded' or pointed toward the sunrise, depending on the energy desired or way it was to be transmitted. The whole point was to connect the design to Creation and represent our own connection in the same way.

"Now the old male Brauchers used horseshoe nails, spikes, and sharpened stakes. My teacher had heard of a large- scale effort using fence posts and hayfork rope that encompassed a whole barnyard and ran back to a prized sick horse in the barn. But he said most male Brauchers stopped using string work long ago. Not for any particular reason, maybe just that it involved too much effort. Not many patients or clients would want to start the effort by digging a bunch of fence post- holes.

"He thought it was in this way that the work passed over to women Braucherins who were already working with strings on a smaller scale. He thought it went from string or yarn between pegs on boards to finer work. He had heard of knitting, crocheting, ribbon work, and embroidery. In this way they could often delegate the work to the client. Some of these works might have even become long term keepsakes, though it seems the intent always was for shorter term results.

"Apparently the string works had an orientation, with the string starting in the 'north' of the work. If you were seeking positive energy you worked clockwise. If you were trying to dispel negative energy you worked counterclockwise. These directions held true for doing things or undoing things. Braucherins claimed to dream the designs, but some might have worked off traditional folk art motifs.

"I have come to see that these strings were the connections to many things. They linked our present to past and future. They were the ties of community and culture. They symbolized our closest relationships. But perhaps most of all they channeled the love of the Brauchers and Braucherin into the larger world.

"If you search hard, as I did, for contacts with the old Braucherei way you will run into many seemingly crusty and cranky individuals. But I now understand that these elders are not scolds, they are carriers of the light. Their strings still reach out to us and lend us their light."

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Postscript: Our Braucher's apprentice made some major life changes and was last heard from living on an American Indian reservation in Arizona.

*Popeye's Fat Cures continued from page 10….*

**Sheep Tallow**: The only specific use that Popeye had for sheep tallow was for use in softening the skin (in the case of chapped or callused hands, feet, etc.) and for use in cases of skin irritation between the legs and in the groin area as he also used bear fat. I expect it would also help to moisturize deeply in the case of eczema or psoriasis.

**Skunk Fat**: Popeye uses skunk fat for very sore throats or very swollen lymph glands around the throat and neck. He specifically said he has used it for mumps. Due to the specificity it has for the lymph glands, I wonder if it could help with some of the lymph swelling that can be so painful in cases of mononucleosis. In the case of extreme lymph swelling, Popeye said to rub the skunk fat into the skin of the neck and all over the areas where the swollen lymph glands are, and wrap a towel or scarf around the outside to keep the grease from staining other clothes or furniture. He also made sure to say that the fat does not smell like skunk!

Interestingly, though this seems to be the oddest of the fat cures Popeye told us of, it is one that we also found recorded in an old PA German Society book. So there is at least one other reference to this cure (despite its strange appearance to our modern eyes), which seems either to point to its prevalence or efficacy. In the PA German Society book there was one difference: it was recommended that the scarf used to wrap the neck after the application of warmed skunk fat should be of red wool tied on with red string.

**Wild Rabbit Fat**: Wild Rabbit Fat is used primarily as a drawing salve for splinters and infections. It has a lovely, flowery smell to it. Popeye said that the glands from the underarms and groin of the rabbit, as well as the kidneys of the rabbit should be rendered out in the fat to add some drawing qualities to it. I think it is relatively likely that the rendered fat of domesticated rabbits raised for meat could be used for the same purposes as wild rabbit fat. Some traditional butchers such as Dietrich's meats in Kutztown, PA still carry rabbit meat.
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# "From "Nanny's Remedy Book"

## der Huuschde (Coughs)

~Elecampane root, ground ivy sage and fennel- a handful of each, covered with water and boiled into tea. Drunk 2-3 times a day for rough cough.

~An electuary is made combining equal parts honey and fresh elderberries heated on the fire until the berries have collapsed and the honey begins to thicken. The end result should be thick, like dense fruit jam. 1 spoonful as needed for a tight cough on the chest.

~A Lehigh County remedy: Boil 3-5 onions together, pressing out the juice as they boil with the back of a spoon and reduce liquid until sweet and thickened slightly. Mix in some strong sage tea sweetened with a lump of brown sugar. Take by spoonfuls while still hot for bronchitis. Tastes good!!

~ For a chronic cough (der alda Huuschde) boil hyssop with honey and figs in a half a glass of wine. Take as needed

~Take 1 heaping quart blue huckleberries (blueberries) and cover with 2 quarts of good gin.. Let set for a minimum of four days. Drink a half a gill (1/8 c.) every morning and evening

~ From York County: Peel and slice (thin) white turnips-you may add fresh dug elecampane root cut into round pieces-but just turnips will work too. Strew a layer of sugar in the bottom of the pan. Add one layer of turnip slices, then a layer of sugar. Alternate layers until the pan is full. Pour some water over the contents and cover the pot well. Set over the fire and let seethe until the whole has turned into jelly or electuary. Give the patient three spoonfuls every day-morning noon and evening. This is surely a good remedy that I have tried in many different instances where recovery always followed it's use.

*These recipes are reprinted for their interesting historical and cultural significance only

See page 5 for topical remedies used for coughs and sore throats

# How to Have Fun with Groundhogs *by Matthew Sicher*

What does Mary Poppins say? "A spoonful of sugar helps the medicine go down." This is also true with language, especially grammar. How better to keep the Pennsylvania Deitsch language alive than to make it fun?

This is precisely what the Grundsau Lodge (Groundhog Lodge) has been doing since after World War One. The first Grundsau Lodge was formed in 1933 as a response to the generally negative sentiment about German languages since the war. Though of course Pennsylvania German culture and language had nothing to do with the horrors that took place throughout Europe, it was nonetheless mighty unpopular to be associated with anything German at the time.

It's always a challenge to keep an island culture alive, while still being part of the larger culture. Grundsau Lodges have been, and continue to be great places for local culture, food, and plenty of jokes. Of course the greatest challenge now facing the future of the Grundsau Lodge can be readily seen at any events. Most of the participants and attendants are age sixty and older, and attendance is steadily declining.

Through the Three Sisters Center we've been trying get creative about making it fun to learn about this culture and language. Along with Rob Lusch of deitscherei.org, the Paul Kunkel of the Grundsau Lodge, and Rob Reynolds of Kutztown University's Cultural Heritage Center, we have been working to create a group of younger people capable of taking on the load of students hoping to learn Deitsch. We hope to begin new classes in the spring. These first classes will be at the beginner level, but we hope to create a real network of teachers and classes that will cover students from beginner level to advanced.

This language initiative is an important challenge, because there are so many aspects of traditional culture, any traditional culture, which can only really be understood and continued from within the context of that culture's language. Traditional culture can certainly still add great depth and value to our lives now and in the future, but we will lose too much if we allow local language to fall away. I'm speaking with great affection for our Deitsch culture, but I recognize the continued value of countless traditional cultures.

In a recent interview I conducted with Paul Kunkel, longtime Grundsau Grossdaadi and tireless promoter of Deitsch language, we discussed the current state of Deitsch, as well as future thoughts and concerns. Paul has been involved with Deitsch language teaching for decades now, and he had distinct concerns for the future of our language and the integrity of our culture. I spoke with him while we were both at this year's Kutztown Folk Festival, a yearly folk-culture festival focused on the Pennsylvania Deitsch people.

Paul voiced a concern that, "in twenty years from now, there will be virtually no native Deitsch speakers left who are not in the plain sects (Amish, Mennonite, etc.)." He conceded that there would certainly remain pockets of native speakers, but he feared that they would be few and far between. I will say that he acknowledged this with a smile after I reminded him that Jesse and I will be raising our child (due in November, another Scorpio…) speaking Deitsch in the home.

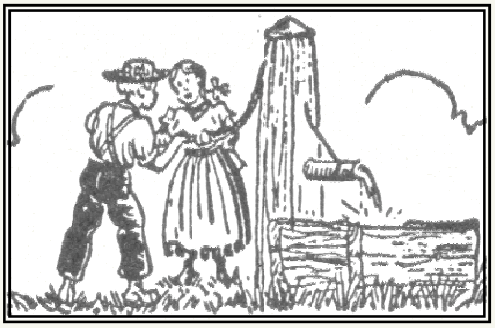
Paul spoke of a time in his childhood when Deitsch was not only spoken in our rural areas, but also in the nearby cities of Allentown and Reading. It is now virtually unheard of for Deitsch to be casually spoken on town and city streets. His point about the prevalence of this language in cities is an important one. It seems the primary challenge to traditional cultures today is the pervasiveness of so many other influences, and nowhere is this so apparent as in towns and cities.

This is a difficult line to walk. I am a great proponent of diverse influences for each one of us, and each of our communities. It is in our best interest, however, to find and sustain a way of both embracing the diversity that makes a nation and a people strong, while continuing to live the wisdom of our own local and genetic heritage. In order for diversity to be meaningful, we all need true and healthy examples of how to live a life within the folds of each culture present. It has been my experience that the best way for me to honor the wisdom of another culture is to consider this new information through the lens of "my own" traditional culture, which may act for me as safe port and bedrock.

Throughout the history of Pennsylvania German culture, small family farms have been one of the defining characteristics of our people. Think of global culture as a farm. Small, highly diversified family farms are far more resilient when faced with economic changes and upheavals than homogenous, monoculture farms. Highly diversified culture may as well be more resilient to upheaval and change. But just like a farm, this is only the case if each element, each contributing cultural influence, is strong and healthy enough to contribute in a real way to the abundance of all.

…continued on next page…

# Die Blaudderei ~ The Babblery *by Jesse Tobin*



For months, now, there have been articles in Hollerbeier Haven about the Deitsch language. In our classes and workshops, and truly, whenever we speak, there is an emphasis on the importance of learning and passing on the 'Deitsch Mudderschprooch' (PA German Mother Tongue). Many people have asked us in the past where they can learn, what classes are available. Up until now there have been many classes available through the Grundsau Lodge organization. For years they have provided affordable beginner courses throughout the Berks and Lehigh County areas. This year, however, will be their last.

Too many of the Grundsau Lodge teachers have decided to retire from their constant teaching and speaking schedules, and Paul Kunkel was the last. This September he will step down from his post in the Grundsau Lodge as the main organizer of the Deitsch classes. One of the only other course options that remain open to the wider community is the Kutztown University Deitsch language course. Unfortunately, for many people this course is too cost prohibitive to make it a realistic option.

Due to all of these factors, the Three Sisters' Center has decided to come together with the PA German Cultural Heritage Center, the Grundsau Lodges, and Deitscherei.org to create a series of courses for the community that are both high quality and affordable. We hope to make a series of at least 3 or 4 classes, which will aim to bring students up to a high level of speaking and writing proficiency by their completion. The classes will have different groups of people in mind. Some will focus on those elders who were raised hearing and possibly even speaking Deitsch, this course will focus on returning these elders to fluent speech and also give them the written skills they may have bypassed in their youth. Another will focus on the younger crowd of people who have never known Deitsch, and even those who have never had classes in standard German. This course will help the younger folks to learn the grammar and vocabulary in a complete and coherent way, and will focus heavily on speaking ability. The third focus will be on families who want to learn Deitsch together: parents or grandparents and children (we think the children will probably learn the fastest!).

These courses will not be in place until the Spring of 2009, at best. This fall, our own Rob Lusch will be helping several of us Deitsch speakers to brush up on our speaking skills and grammar so that we will be prepared with an army of teachers for all levels in the spring. We will keep you updated as our plans progress. As of now, our Blaudderei course has 8 students who have committed to developing these skills and preparing to teach, but we are always in search of more!!! Classes will begin September 9th and meet every Tuesday of the Fall Semester at the PA German Cultural Heritage Center from 7-9 pm. Anyone who is advanced in their command of Pennsylfaanisch Deitsch, and interested in helping to create an affordable and accessible course of community wide classes, please contact us and let us know of your interest.

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...Fun with Groundhogs continued from previous page:

Childhood is the best and most effective time to begin living these patterns of supporting true and vibrant diversity by consciously sustaining one's own traditional ways. Paul Kunkel expressed without hesitation that the single most effective way to ensure the continuation of the Deitsch language is to raise children speaking and hearing Deitsch from their first days. "It is important for children to grow up knowing that it is possible to be a part of their Deitsch culture, as well as English culture; to be a part of local tradition, and part of America as a whole."

Children must be raised encircled by the same supportive arms of tradition as their grandmothers and grandfathers knew in their childhoods. We have the blessing of choice and opportunity now all around us. May we choose to embrace the empowering and useful wisdom of our own traditions, both family and cultural, for all children thrive on consistent and loving guidance. I pray that this constancy and guidance come not only from the steadfast family, but also from the very traditions in which our elders lived and grew. And for those of us who are no longer children, it is never too late to begin.

*...The Tree of Life continued from page 6....*

This last helper will be a Zwarichfraa (dwarf woman) in the case of male practitioner and a Zwarichmann (dwarf man) in the case of a female practitioner. This is thought to be a possible origin of the cross gender training.

Another woman from Union County also spoke of the tree of life with similarities and differences to the one from Perry County. She too said that each Braucher needs to find the way that works for them. She believed that Brauchers can and will work in all three levels but only master one of them. The upper world she called der Heechstblatz and had Hellgraft or a bright power. The middle world or earth, die Newicherd had a sharp power, die Schaafgraft . She referred to the lower world as a spirit cave, which she called die Geisschthielhling. This lower world she said had hard power, die Hattgraft. A Braucher could be der Himmelschoffer, a sky worker, who worked with the sun, moon, stars, and was in almost constant contact with other worlds. A Braucher who worked with the earth was called der Erdschoffer and they were in contact with plants, nature, water, rocks, and animals. She had no term for one who worked in the under world.

Even though these two Brauchers had different methods and words that they used, they still had the same basic concepts. There were still three distinctions between the upper world, middle world, and lower world. I find within all of the transcripts there are parallels between the Brauchers' stories. The presence of these universal of themes of shamanic practice remind us of the availability of this information to all through Spirit. Amazingly, the Brauchers who gave us these interviews had no contact with each other. This is something we find very often in interviews: themes and elements of Braucherei tradition are present throughout areas of Pennsylvania Deitsch habitation and infuse themselves completely into the local healing practices. It's also interesting to note the combined presence of Pre-Christian elements alongside commonly held Christian themes.

With each interview we find it is more and more apparent to us that this tradition we carry truly is "en Brauch" (an heirloom). Like an ancient wooden tool it has been passed down through countless generations. Each hand that has touched it has left behind the marks of use: the nicks, scratches, and dents are unavoidable to a tradition that has survived at least two millennia. With those marks, however have come the smoothness and high polish of a handle worn with love, and rendered only more valuable and useful with its obvious antiquity.

**Kutztown Area Historical Society**

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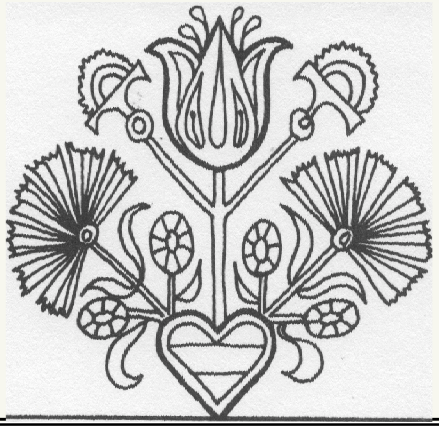


A homespun woolen thread tied about the neck will cure croup!

The PA German dialect translation on page 5

# Blumme-Schterne: Flower Stars *by Patrick Donmoyer*

Hex Signs are perhaps one of the most ambiguous artistic expressions proceeding from the Pennsylvania German culture. Adorning the facades of German-style bank-barns across the south-eastern mid-section of the state, these rosettes and geometric star designs inspire awe and ask of us to question, from whence did they originate and with what intention were they created?

We need look no further than the names by which they have been called to discover a multitude of possible implications. Hex signs, blumme-schterne (German for flower stars), and barn stars are all terms which indicate a relationship between humans and the celestial. The term barn star appeared in response to the widely used term Hex sign, as a scholarly attempt to clarify what was believed to be a misassociation between the symbols and the occult. However obscure esoteric knowledge is not necessary to see that these symbols take the shapes of celestial bodies. Suns, moons, and stars appear to reference the human interest in our relationship to the heavens, to the seasons, and our place in time. The orbits of the stars not only define our concepts of time, but our forbearers used the stars to orchestrate the details of their planting and harvesting, ultimately their livelihood. These symbols carry the strength and wisdom of thousands of years of observation of the heavens and an understanding of humanity's place in the vast universe. The term Blumme Schterne takes this idea one step further by linking the observation of plant geometry with celestial design, almost as if to remind us that as it is above, so it is below. Blossoms are revered for their fragile beauty, their medicinal benefits, and their intensity of color. One could see Hex signs as combining the elements of celestial understanding with the beauty and beneficence of flowers.

On one hand, academic researchers would have us believe that these elaborately painted symbols have little or no meaning beyond folk decoration and that they function merely as emblems of local identity. On the other hand, popular opinion tends to favor the more carefully constructed commercial interpretations which can be traced to the folk-culture craze of the 1950s and 60s. Both of these explanations leave much to be desired in bringing these symbols to light. While both describe the full range of possible contemporary interpretations today, both fail to establish a firm connection to the attitudes of our forbearers and their motivations for painting them. And let us be honest with ourselves for a moment - we must remember that we can never completely understand the beauty and complexity of the past, we merely accept one agreed-upon, constructed, historical fiction or another.

The earliest historical record would have us accept that hex signs appeared shortly after the Civil War, when commercial paints became widely available, and farmers wanted their barns decorated. However many examples exist that tell us a different story. These were signs used as date plaques, inset into the original masonry of the gable ends of barns possibly dating to just before the turn of the 19th century. One such example can be found just north of Lenhartsville on Rt 143, in Berks county.

While new evidence continues to appear to challenge our notions of when these signs first appeared on barns, there is no question that these symbols have been a part of our culture for thousands of years. For the past several centuries these star designs appear on everything from dower chests and other furniture, to tools, pottery, and illuminated documents such as birth and baptismal certificates. Some scholars point to this as evidence that the symbols on barns bear no special significance because of their profusion on common, everyday objects. But on the contrary, this could mean that these symbols were held in such high esteem that they found their way into every aspect of life, that the symbols were not only meant to adorn but also to remind us of our celestial origins and our connections to the sacred cycles and patterns of all life.

Most importantly, Hex signs speak for themselves through the powerful vibration and rotation of their beauty, form and symmetry. Look upon these symbols and observe their affect upon you. Feel the awe-inspiring vision of their presence that transcends all interpretation. Look upon them with joy and move with them through the cycles of life.

## 'Der Braucherei Weg'

**The Braucher's Path**

12 Month Course

Next session begins January 2009

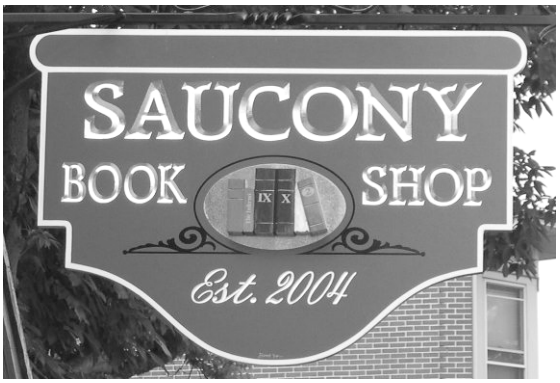
Now Available on CD for Distance Learning !

For more information

Contact Jesse at

484-336-4611






The Saucony Book Shop, located in the heart of scenic rural Berks County, epicenter of Pennsylvania German folk culture, offers a full range of gently used, rare, and antiquarian books, with many volumes of scholarly merit and an unabashed emphasis on the quaint, the curious, and the utterly obscure.

Store hours: T W F 12-6 p.m.,

Sat. 10 a.m.-5 p.m.

**41 West Main St.**

**Kutztown, Pennsylvania 19530**



Farm at Coventry's

## "Homestead Herbalism"

9-Month Course

Next session begins March 2009

Www.FarmatCoventry.com

Special Sunday at Farm at Coventry !

**September 14th, 2008**

Herb Walk and Lecture with

**David Winston, AHG**

"Treating Lyme Disease with Orthodox & Complimentary Therapies"

David Winston, AHG, Dean of the prestigious **Center for Herbal Studies** in Washington, NJ www.herbalstudies.org has been scheduled for a rare , but much anticipated return to the Farm! As one of our nations' most respected herbalists, this is a day not to be missed. The class will begin promptly at 10 am. Cost $100 A local, certified organic lunch will be provided for an additional $15

**SOLD OUT!**

www.FarmatCoventry.com

# 'Hollerbeier Haven' Guild Gatherings in Kutztown, PA

**August 30, 2008- "Wheel of the Year, Part 1"** During our August gathering we will discuss the dark half of the year, from Alleliebeziel (Halloween) to Walpurgisnacht (May Eve). The information we will be sharing comes predominantly out of the Oley Braucherei Freindschaft. We will focus on the major and minor feasts acknowledged in the Braucherei tradition during this part of the year. In addition to this we will explore the significance of each of the six moons, of this half of the year. We will discuss the significance of each moon from the perspective of the Greek Zodiac and the Oley-Pikeville moon Calendar.

**September 27, 2008- Wheel of the Year Part 2** Our September gathering will focus on the Light half of the year, from Walpurgisnacht (May Eve) to Alleliebeziel (Halloween). The information we will be sharing comes predominantly out of the Oley Braucherei Freindschaft. We will focus on the major and minor feasts acknowledged in the Braucherei tradition during this part of the year. In addition to this we will explore the significance of each of the six moons, of this half of the year. We will discuss the significance of each moon from the perspective of the Greek Zodiac and the Oley-Pikeville moon Calendar

**October 28, 2008– Herbs and Hex Signs** The October gathering will feature guest teachers Susan Hess and Patrick Donmoyer who will split the day speaking on their own respective areas of interest. Patrick will discuss his research and knowledge of the history of hex signs in Berks County and Susan will do a presentation of the Medicinal and Folkloric uses of PA German Herbs.

There will be no Guild Gatherings during the months of November and December

***All Gatherings will be held at the Kutztown Historical Society on the last Saturday of the month from 10-3pm (unless otherwise noted) $35 members/$45 non-members. To register call Jesse at 484-336-4611 or email her at Thr3Sisters@aol.com**

# 'Herbal Hands' Workshops and Classes in Pottstown, PA will resume in early 2009. A full schedule will appear in the next issue of Hollerbeier Haven. For up-to-date schedule additions please visit www.FarmatCoventry.com

Bringing in the Harvest!!

*** All Herbal Hands Workshops will be held at the Farm at Coventry on the first Saturday of the month from 10-3pm and cost $40 (unless otherwise noted) . To register call Susan at 610-469-9591 or visit www.FarmatCoventry.com to register online**

The hops have been pulled from the vines

Three Sisters Center
for the Healing Arts
P.O. Box 88
Kempton, PA
19529

Visit our newly updated website ! www.ThreeSistersCenter.com

*This tiny article was discovered by one of our members in a box of old newspapers and magazines and shared because of it's urgency, even as it holds true today. The date written on the article is Thursday May 5, 1949. There is no author listed, but it is understood that he must have been a man concerned about his ailing heritage to raise his voice in such a way. We feel his sense of pride all these many years later and are reprinting it here, in part, for all to experience now, timely as it is... and to let him know, whomever he may be...we're not sneering.*

# STOP SNEERING !!

"We must erase the word 'superstition' from our vocabulary!! Do you see why? Everyone who uses this word puts himself on a high pedestal and laughs and sneers at his fellow man. If we would study our folklore-or any folklore at all, for that matter-we cannot permit ourselves to do this. Rather, we must approach this phase of our traditional culture, which we so aptly call "alda weiverglawwa" (old wives' beliefs) in Pennsylvania Dutch, with the open mind of a student, with a little more reverence even. NOW I KNOW this will shock many of you, but please hear me out. Thirty years ago America laughed at and ridiculed our PA Dutch folk art. Today the whole nation stands in awe of it. What I am striving for is a similar appreciation on your part of our folk beliefs... "What in the soul of a man has continued giving life to a particular folk belief?" One thing we must remember-the mere fact that a folk belief continues to live on, often underground-is testimony that it is filling a need in a man's soul. Once you begin to look upon folk beliefs in this light, you will wipe from your minds the repulsive word 'superstition' and introduce the positive expression 'folk belief'. I KNOW people have been taught to feel ashamed of folk beliefs. Now I come to ask you in all the seriousness that I can command, to respect them...We, the PA Dutch were taught for generations to despise and disrespect our traditional culture. The task that we of the PA DUTCHMAN have set ourselves is to teach NOT hate, NOT disrespect, but UNDERSTANDING, APPRECIATION and most important of all, a LOVE FOR OUR HERITAGE. Unprejudice yourself....."